

⚡ RAPID DOWNLOAD #4: TAKING ACTION



2MIN



Read this the first time a player receives the spotlight and can take an action with their PC:

Time to take action!

Every player action can have three steps: **narration**, **roll**, and **Effects**.

Start by **narrating** your character's action. If your character is only casually looking around, moving around, or conversing, I (the MC) will narrate how the scene responds to you or what you see.

When the action you describe has an uncertain outcome and is also dramatic – in other words, you're not just waving your hand, you're doing something whose outcome we're all eager to know – I will ask you to continue to the next step, and **make a roll**.

To make a roll, first count your action's **Power**. Every positive tag, such as a power tag, gives your action 1 Power and every negative tag, such as a weakness tag, reduces your action's Power by 1.

Only tags that are directly relevant to the action count! For example **marksmanship** is positive for shooting while the target's **cover** is negative, and **charming** is irrelevant. I will be the final arbitrator for which tags are relevant.

If there are statuses that affect your action, add the tier of the best status to your Power and subtract the tier of the worst status. Note that it's not just your tags and status that affect your action's Power, but also tags and statuses that your enemy has or in the environment, which I will tell you about.

Stop reading, and let the player count their Power before continuing:

Once you know your action's Power, roll two six-sided dice and add your Power to the result. If your total is:

- **6 or less, it's a miss.** Your action fails or backfires, causing Consequences.
- **7-9, it's a mixed hit.** Your action turns in your favor but still has Consequences.
- **10 or more, it's a strong hit.** Your action turns in your favor without Consequences. You can still choose to take Consequences, in return to an even greater success.

This **quick outcome** might be enough in many cases. Let's resolve this action as a quick outcome and learn about the third step, Effects, later. Go ahead, roll the dice!

Once a player can envision the current scene and has the spotlight, they can take an action with their character. This is where the magic of the game happens: the lead characters' actions are what shape the story for better or for worse. Whether they succeed or fail, luckily avoid repercussions or suffer grave Consequences later, it's the players' actions that drive the adventure.

Every player action can have one, two, or three phases:

- Narration
- Narration with a roll – called a **quick outcome**
- Narration with a roll and Effects – called a **tracked outcome**

These phases follow one another if and when the MC requests them: narration can lead to a roll, and a roll can lead to Effects. This is up for the MC's discretion, based on what the player wishes to achieve with their action as well as cinematic considerations [see **Quick vs. Tracked Conflicts**, page 96].

1 NARRATION

The player always begins their action by simply describing what their PC is attempting to do. As long as the outcome of their action is either **certain** or **non-dramatic** (or both), the MC just listens and interjects only to add relevant details.

Sometimes, that's where the action ends. If the PC does something dramatic where the outcome is certain, the MC can deliver Consequences if she deems it appropriate and then go on to Establish how the action affected the scene. Or, if the PC does something mundane, which has no direct dramatic implications (yet), the story moves on without going into the action in great depth.

When the action is both uncertain and dramatic, the MC may ask the player to move to the next phase and make a roll, to determine the outcome.

Special consideration is deserved when a PC is **perceiving**, **moving**, or **conversing**.

Perceiving details in the scene that are readily available to the PC is not a dramatic action (even if what is seen is dramatic). As part of their narration phase, the player can describe what the PC is looking at, listening for, smelling, etc., and the MC responds with any new information that the PC perceives, which may include newly-revealed Challenges and even Threats (essentially re-Establishing). Once the PC attempts to obtain information that isn't readily available, such as searching a room, locating an opponent while *blinded*, or using mythic powers to see spirits – the action becomes dramatic and may move on to the next phase.

Movement in *Otherscape*, even in combat, is assumed to be certain and undramatic, unless the movement itself is challenging or faces resistance. During conflicts, a PC can reasonably move and reposition themselves in a scene before taking a dramatic action or as part of a dramatic action. For example, they can charge an opponent, or move closer to someone they want to talk to simply by the player describing it as a part of their action.

Movement requires a roll when it is uncertain and dramatic in and of itself. For example, if a PC tries to walk to a defended battle position, or while *wounded*, this very movement becomes an uncertain and dramatic action. Other examples include attempting to climb a building or piloting a drone through a narrow ravine. It is ultimately up to the MC when movement requires a roll in and of itself. If so, the PC must spend their spotlight moving to their desired position and can take their intended action only if the movement succeeds and only on their next spotlight.

In-game conversations between PCs and NPCs often start narratively, just by describing what the PCs and NPCs say, but then someone says something charged or tries to get what they want out of the conversation, and the outcome becomes uncertain and dramatic, kicking in the next phase.

WHAT IS DRAMATIC, WHAT IS CERTAIN

There are many ways to interpret drama and certainty, but at your table, the MC is the final arbitrator on that. The following definitions can help.

Certain here means that there are no major hurdles to succeed in this action or that the hurdles are not worth getting into. It's either a really simple action (picking one's nose) or the PC has already established control of the situation and now we want to see what they would do with it (abandoning a prisoner in the wastelands). Any certainty can be questioned; the MC chooses what is worth questioning in your game. Sometimes foregoing a roll is more powerful than asking for one.

Dramatic here means a compelling part of the story, which usually happens when something is at stake or when the PCs have something to lose. Ask yourself, if this were a movie, would this action be performed over a dynamic soundtrack? Would there be a close-up shot on the protagonist's face showing how they feel or think, or how much effort they put in during this action? Would we care if it succeeds or not? If so, it's a dramatic action.

Narration for perceiving, moving, or conversing does not take a player's entire spotlight if it is a prelude to other actions and is not dramatic in and of itself. A PC may do any of these in the lead up to their dramatic action and then take a dramatic action all within a single spotlight.

NARRATION EXAMPLES

Certain action

Player: I walk over to the launch console and hit the missile launch button.

MC: Okay... It's your funeral. (Delivering Consequences:) The room starts to shudder and lights blink red as the missile launch sequence begins.

Non-dramatic action

Player: I go to the vending machine and get a soda.

MC: Which flavor?

Player: "Acid Rain." My favorite.

MC: They're out.

Perceiving

Player: I inch to the building corner and quickly look into the alley. What do I see?

MC: Your informant is standing by a garbage compressor, checking her holographic feeds, all tense. She seems unharmed but nervous. Something is wrong. This smells like a trap.

Conversation

Player: I ask the hardware dealer, "Did you get a visit from Mutblade lately?"

MC: He shrugs and says, "Nah, haven't seen him around. Why d'you ask?"

Player: "He and I got beef to settle."

MC: "Can't help you there. And don't you hecking settle it in my store."

FOR THE MC: BREAKING UP A COMPLEX ACTION

Sometimes players will narrate their character performing multiple actions at the same time, for example:

- "I run through the flames and open fire at the escaping assault team."
- "I break the occult binding on the lightning elemental, and command it to supercharge the battery cell."
- "I read the room to see who holds the power here, and then I punch them the hardest I can."

Sometimes, it may be appropriate to resolve these related actions as a single action, usually by assuming one of them is certain or not dangerous. As the MC, you could say:

- "Running through the flames doesn't pose a threat, so you can roll to open fire."
- "If you can break the occult binding on the elemental, the elemental will do as you say."
- "It's clear who's the boss around here, so we can just move on to the punching."

Other times, the player is getting ahead of themselves, and it's your role as the MC to help them break up the sequence into singular actions. Ask them to roll for the first action, and explain that the next part may be predicated on their success. The follow-up action may require its own roll, too. As always, it's up to you if they get to keep the spotlight between both actions, or if you move it around to someone else and they must wait until the next spotlight to complete their intended action.

- "Let's see if you get through the fire first. Then you can roll to shoot at your escaping enemies."
- "That elemental won't do what you say so easily. You must first unbind it, and then bind it to you."
- "Roll to read the room. After that you can punch them, if you're still inclined to do that."

2 MAKING A ROLL

When the outcome of the action is both **uncertain and dramatic**, the MC may ask the player to **make a roll** in order to determine the outcome.

When a player makes a roll, they count the action's **Power** and then roll two six-sided dice (or *:Otherscape* dice), adding their Power to the result. The total determines the outcome of the action.

COUNTING POWER

Before rolling the dice, the player and the MC establish the action's Power. Power is determined by all of the tags and statuses that are **relevant** to the action, including:

- The PC's own power tags and weakness tags (of any theme), story tags, and statuses, representing the PC's abilities, flaws, gear, resources, assistance, position, and condition.
- The target's or opponent's tags and statuses, representing the same, but for the target or the opponent
- Tags and statuses in the environment which help or interfere with the action
- The Scale of the action, if it targets more than a single human-sized target (see **Scale**, page 118)

Power represents an action's chances to succeed and also its potential impact. It is the sum of all the influencing factors – tags and statuses – affecting the success of the action, and is unique to each action, changing when the influencing factors change.

ONLY DIRECTLY RELEVANT TAGS AFFECT AN ACTION'S POWER

Directly **helpful** tags (or positive tags) are clearly helpful for the action, like a *gun* and *aiming* help shooting.

- Each positive tag **increases** the action's Power by 1.
- The tier of the best status (the positive status with the highest tier) is **added** to the action's Power.

Directly **impeding** tags (or negative tags) are clearly impeding the action, like *rough terrain* or being *restrained* impedes running.

- Each negative tag **decreases** the action's Power by 1.
- The tier of the worst status (the negative status with the highest tier) is **subtracted** from the action's Power.

Power can be reduced below 0 to a negative number.



:OTHERSCAPE DICE

:Otherscape dice have twelve sides, each showing a number from one to six (there are two faces showing each number), so they are statistically identical to six-sided dice. On each die, the faces with the Self, Mythos, or Noise icon stand for the number 6.

For example, a *gun expert* PC with an *assault rifle* and a *targeting system* firing on a dummy target with no relevant tags has 3 positive tags and therefore a Power of 3. If they also gained the blessing of a wind god in the form of *helpful-winds-2*, they can add the tier of this positive status to their Power, reaching a Power of 5.

On the field, the same PC aiming and shooting at a *fortified-2* mercenary will subtract the tier of this negative status from their power, shooting with only a Power of 3. If the mercenary has a *targeting jamming device* and is obscured by *heavy smog*, both of which are negative tags for this action, the action's Power will be further reduced to 1.

Indirectly relevant tags do not affect an action's power, but you can use them in another, preparatory action to create directly relevant tags. This is especially true when a tag seems useful, but is too far-fetched to be considered directly relevant. This additional action represents the character's attempt to adapt her abilities to her current needs – an attempt which may backfire and have its own Consequences.

For example, being *smart* could help you shoot, but not directly. It will take another intermediary action, such as finding a weakness, for which *smart* is directly helpful, to use Effects and create a tag like *exposed weakness*, which is directly helpful to shooting. In summary, indirectly related tags require an additional separate action in order to boost the intended action.

If the MC requires an additional action to turn an indirectly relevant tag into a directly relevant one, the player may pivot to take that boosting action first, and then take their originally intended action immediately, if the MC approved,

or when they have the spotlight again (see **Keeping The Spotlight**, page 82). This often happens with broad tags (see **Downgrading a Tag**, page 192).

Irrelevant tags do not affect an action's power. An irrelevant tag has nothing to do with the action. E.g., being *charming* doesn't help you swim.

ROLL AND OUTCOME

Once the Power of the action is determined, the player rolls the dice and adds Power to the result. The total of two six-sided dice plus Power determines the outcome of the action:

- **6 or less (6-)** is a **miss**. Something doesn't work as intended and there are adverse Consequences.
- **7-9** is a **mixed hit**. The action succeeds or benefits the PC, but there are still some Consequences.
- **10+** is a **strong hit**. The action succeeds as intended, or better. There are no Consequences. The player may choose to take Consequences for an even greater degree of success.

Rolling **snake eyes** (1 and 1) on the dice is always considered a miss, even if the action's Power would increase the total to above 6. Rolling **boxcars** (6 and 6) on the dice is always considered a strong hit, even if the action's Power would reduce the total below 10.

On a 10+ or 7-9, the player may usually narrate the success of their action, with input from the MC. On a 7-9 or 6-, the MC delivers Consequences immediately after the roll, in the next phase of the scene flow.

QUICK OUTCOMES

For many actions, a single roll is all that is needed to determine the outcome. The table can quickly establish what happened and move on, without getting deeper into game rules.

As the MC, consider a good / mixed / bad answer by imagining the good outcome first – things happen exactly as the player wanted – then going down to worse and worst. The “bad” answer is not necessarily a failure; the PC might be able to accomplish their goal but they also get themselves into a mess.

If the player gets a strong hit and wishes to take Consequences for a greater success, they get something extra. The player describes the great outcome they'd like to achieve and the MC decides if it fits the scope of their action; the MC (and other players) may offer suggestions as well. The player then chooses if they wish to take this deal (Consequences for great success), or keep their good success.

For example:

- Hack a magnetic lock
 - » **Bad:** The door opens but the alarm goes off
 - » **Mixed:** The door opens but the hacker PC got tagged
 - » **Good:** The door opens
 - » **Great:** The hacker PC unlocks all other nearby locks
- Convince a bouncer to let you into a club
 - » **Bad:** The PC is denied entrance
 - » **Mixed:** The PC is let in, but without their gun
 - » **Good:** The PC is let in
 - » **Great:** The PC is let in and the bouncer reveals pertinent information
- Reach cover across a gunfight
 - » **Bad:** The PC gets shot and stumbles midway
 - » **Mixed:** The PC reaches cover but gets shot
 - » **Good:** The PC reaches cover safely
 - » **Great:** The PC reaches cover safely and shoots out an opponent while running
- Find an eye of newt in a dumpster full of rotting occult components
 - » **Bad:** The PC gets so sick they have to stop
 - » **Mixed:** The PC found it, but now they stink
 - » **Good:** The PC found it!
 - » **Great:** The PC found it and also found something else useful

Even with a quick outcome, the MC may still choose to deliver Consequences with Effects (see **Consequences**, page 98). The conditions described above (tagged, shot, stink, sick) can be purely narrative or they can be described with tags.

3 CHOOSING EFFECTS

The third and last optional part of taking action involves choosing game Effects. It is only invoked when the MC wants to track the outcome of the action, that is, to measure it with game elements such as tags and statuses. Choosing Effects is explained in further detail in the next section.